Landscape Architecture
PLACEmaking Team

Development Management Consultation Response Officer: Hannah Griffin Date: 01/02/2023

Reference:	Site:	Proposal:	Case Officer:
S/COND/22/0316	*Land North Of A420, Eastern Villages, Swindon.*	*Discharge of condition 10 (Framework Landscape, Ecology and Arboricultural Management Plan)*	*Ed Snook*

Summary of Landscape response

No Comment/No Objection	☐
No Objection/ Subject to conditions	☐
Not acceptable in its current form/ subject to changes described below	☒
Objection in principle	☐

Executive Summary

Thank you for consulting the Landscape Section of the PLACEmaking Team for advice regarding this discharge of condition application.

A Framework Landscape, Ecology and Arboricultural Management Plan has been submitted for clearance of Condition 10 of S/OUT/13/1555, which states:

10. Framework, Landscape, Ecology and Arboricultural Management Plan (FLEAMP) Prior to the submission of the first reserved matters at South Marston or Rowborough, a Framework Landscape, Ecology and Arboricultural Management Plan (FLEAMP) for that village in broad accordance with the Biodiversity Enhancement Options Plan (DN 1796-L03 D) (submitted to LPA on 7th September 2017) shall have been submitted to and approved in writing by the Local Planning Authority. The FLEAMPs shall provide an overarching management plan for the development at South Marston and Rowborough. The FLEAMPs shall:
a) Identify the feature specific objectives to achieve the overarching aim;
b) Provide measures to enhance the biodiversity of South Marston Brook through appropriate management of bank side vegetation, the re-grading of bank profiles and reconnecting the South Marston Brook with its floodplain to create greater morphological diversity and a range of floodplain features such as scrapes and wetlands;
c) Provide the location, principles of design, purpose, function, buffer zone and construction of the wet features (ponds and SuDS), including connectivity of water features and designs which minimise the disturbance of wetland and riverine habitats, particularly watervoles;
d) Provide a strategy for net biodiversity gain and enhancement and new priority habitat creation including advanced mitigation and protective measures during construction, long term protection objectives, habitat connectivity, a maintenance schedule and proposals for allowing and restricting public access;

e) Identify the additional green infrastructure that will be created. The development shall be laid out and made available for use in accordance with the approved FLEAMPs. The submitted FLEAMPs shall be in accord with the approved Open Space Parameter Plan.
Reason: To ensure biodiversity, green infrastructure and assets are protected, integrated with the development and enhanced in accordance with Policies SD3, EN1 and NC3 of the Swindon Borough Local Plan 2026. The FLEAMPs shall also ensure the development provides access to nature to promote human well-being and afford educational opportunities.

Overview:
Overall the FLEAMP is acceptable, with a view to further detail being submitted in the form of LEAMPs with Reserved Matters applications. There is some lack of practical detail of how landscape elements and habitats will be installed and managed, to ensure their successful establishment. A FLEAMP should include ecology requirements and practical landscape management prescriptions, with landscape consultant input if necessary. The FLEAMP should also aim for an attractive, functional and fit for purpose landscape. Please see my comments below.

Comments

1. New tree planting:

1.1. Any trees other than whips or feathers planted as part of hedgerow or woodland area, of small standard size (8-10cm girth) or above will require regular watering to ensure successful establishment. 4.39 states trees will be watered 'in periods of extreme drought'. This is not adequate. For at least the first year trees will need to be watered at least weekly during periods of low or no rainfall. They should be watered to field capacity each time via irrigation tubing.

1.2. Management plan should state that any trees that fail within the first 5 years will be replaced by the management company at their own cost. (Trees failing within the first year will be replaced by the contractor who has installed them).

2. Woodland and scrub planting:

2.1. Newly planted woodland and scrub planting must be kept weed free to avoid competition from weeds for water (it is not feasible to water this kind of planting and should not be necessary). This is usually either done by spot weeding with weedkiller or preferably by the installation of mulch mats around the base of the plants when they are planted.

2.2. Again, failures will need to be replaced, as above.

3. Grassland habitat:

3.1. 4.49 'Modified grassland' outlines the target criteria but does not detail how this will be achieved. What would the mowing and management regime be? Would be useful to add a point

that this should be done without use of chemicals. Add specification for mowing height (not too low) to ensure amenity grassland is resilient to drought and kept healthy so it is not necessary to use chemical fertilisers and weedkiller. Edges of paths can also be kept mown where they go through wildflower areas which gives them a designed appearance. Alongside the ecological criteria for management, these areas are managed for a certail purpose/ use.

3.2. Neutral grassland: please clarify the approach where there are high phosphate levels. This is very likely where there have been arable fields and is very challenging to remedy.

4. SUDs

4.1. Cannot rely on natural colonisation of swales etc. These should be sown/ planted, with mix of native aquatics, marginals etc. as specified in the back of the document. Ponds with standing water will need the addition of floating aquatics that are oxygenators.

5. Orchards

5.1. Orchards are proposed within the Design Codes. Please add a section on orchards to the FLEAMP.